

Sample Conversations

50 Advisor–Sidekick Exchanges

Each conversation shows a real advisor question followed by Sidekick’s response, sourced from the knowledge base. Use these to evaluate response quality, identify errors, and build your QA framework.

CONVERSATION 1 · Article 1

ADVISOR

What’s the minimum number of rooms needed for a hotel group booking?

SIDEKICK

For hotel group bookings at Fora, the minimum is 10+ rooms. Once you reach this threshold, you’ll work with the hotel’s group sales team instead of booking individual reservations. Groups qualify for special rates, contracts, and benefits like complimentary rooms based on the size of your block.

CONVERSATION 2 · Article 4

ADVISOR

What attrition should I negotiate for a wedding block?

SIDEKICK

For wedding blocks, I’d recommend aiming for 15% attrition as your starting point. Wedding groups usually have firm headcounts since guest lists are finalized months in advance, making attendance predictable. This gives you a good rate while managing risk.

CONVERSATION 3 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What’s a cut-off date?

SIDEKICK

A cut-off date is the deadline to finalize your rooming list and release unused rooms back to the hotel. Typically set 30-60 days before arrival, this is when:

- Unused rooms are released
- The group is charged for rooms up to the attrition minimum
- The hotel can resell released inventory

Pro tip: Set your internal cut-off 7-10 days before the hotel’s deadline to give yourself a buffer.

CONVERSATION 4 · Article 9

ADVISOR

What commission do Hyatt groups pay?

SIDEKICK

Hyatt groups typically pay 8-10% commission depending on the property. Major chains like Marriott, Hilton, Hyatt, and IHG generally fall in the 8-10% range for group bookings.

CONVERSATION 5 · Article 1

ADVISOR

How many cabins do I need for a cruise group?

SIDEKICK

Cruise groups require a minimum of 8+ staterooms. Keep in mind that cruise lines measure groups by staterooms/cabins, not passengers. So a cabin with 2 passengers counts as 1 cabin toward your group minimum, and a cabin with 4 passengers also counts as just 1 cabin.

CONVERSATION 6 · Article 7

ADVISOR

What's the difference between speculative and contracted cruise groups?

SIDEKICK

Great question! Here's the breakdown:

Speculative Hold (Spec):

- Non-committal hold on cabins
- No initial deposit required
- Can release cabins without penalty
- Cruise line can recall cabins with notice (recall date)
- Best for testing interest or uncertain headcount

Contracted Group:

- Formal commitment with deposit (typically 10-20%)
- Minimum cabin requirement with attrition clause
- Better pricing and amenities than spec
- Locked-in rates
- Best for committed groups of 15+ cabins

CONVERSATION 7 · Article 10

ADVISOR

Should I use a DMC or tour operator for my corporate group's trip?

SIDEKICK

It depends on what your corporate group is looking for:

Tour Operator: Best for pre-packaged itineraries and budget-conscious groups. Good if your company wants a standard experience with set pricing.

DMC: Best for custom experiences and VIP treatment. Good if your company wants unique activities and high-touch service.

What's your group size, destination, and budget range? That would help narrow down the better option.

CONVERSATION 8 · Article 1

ADVISOR

Do group bookings get preferred partner perks?

SIDEKICK

No, group bookings do not offer preferred partner perks and amenities. This is an important difference from individual (FIT) bookings. Groups follow different processes and typically involve contracts, special group rates, and group-specific benefits like complimentary rooms, but not the standard preferred partner perks.

CONVERSATION 9 · Article 2

ADVISOR

How many rooms do I need for a hotel group?

SIDEKICK

For hotel groups, you need 8+ rooms to qualify for group rates. Once you reach this threshold, you'll work with the hotel's group sales team to negotiate contracts and special terms.

CONVERSATION 10 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What's the standard complimentary room ratio for hotel groups?

SIDEKICK

The standard complimentary room ratio is 1:40, meaning you receive one complimentary room for every 40 paid rooms. For example:

- 80 paid rooms = 2 comp rooms
- 45 paid rooms = 1 comp room
- 35 paid rooms = 0 comp rooms

Comp rooms can be used for the group organizer, tour manager, or sold to reduce client costs.

CONVERSATION II · Article 3

ADVISOR

What's attrition and how does it work?

SIDEKICK

Attrition is the minimum percentage of your room block that must be filled. Industry standard is 20-30% attrition, meaning your group must fill 70-80% of the block. For example, if you have a 50-room block with 20% attrition, your group must fill at least 40 rooms. If you only fill 38 rooms, you'd owe payment for the 2-room shortfall.

CONVERSATION I2 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What items are typically negotiable in a hotel group contract?

SIDEKICK

You can typically negotiate:

Rates:

- Base room rate
- Discounts for larger groups
- Shoulder date flexibility

Amenities:

- Complimentary breakfast
- Welcome reception
- Room upgrades
- Late checkout
- Resort fee waivers

Terms:

- Attrition percentage
- Cut-off date extension
- Deposit schedule adjustments
- Flexible cancellation terms

Meeting Space:

- Complimentary meeting rooms
- AV equipment
- Wi-Fi access

CONVERSATION 13 · Article 2

ADVISOR

What's the cruise group minimum?

SIDEKICK

Cruise groups require a minimum of 5+ cabins. This is the industry standard threshold for accessing group rates and benefits like TC Credits and CAP Points.

CONVERSATION 14 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What's ROH mean in a hotel contract?

SIDEKICK

ROH stands for "Run of House." This means the hotel assigns room types based on availability at check-in rather than guaranteeing specific room categories for your group. The hotel ensures appropriate accommodations, but your group doesn't get to choose specific room types upfront. ROH is common for groups and often comes with better rates in exchange for this flexibility.

CONVERSATION 15 · Article 4

ADVISOR

Should I push for lower attrition to get better rates?

SIDEKICK

Yes! Lower attrition percentages often result in better rates from hotels. If you're confident about your group size and have already collected deposits from travelers, pushing for 10-15% attrition can significantly improve your pricing. Just make sure you calculate the worst-case scenario penalty before agreeing.

CONVERSATION 16 · Article 8

ADVISOR

What are TC Credits on cruises?

SIDEKICK

TC Credits (Tour Conductor Credits) are rewards earned based on your cruise group size. You typically earn approximately 1 TC credit per 8-10 cabins booked (exact rate varies by cruise line).

TC Credits can be redeemed for:

1. Free cabin for group leader/tour conductor
2. Onboard events or amenities (private party, specialty dining, shore excursions)
3. Additional commission (convert credit to extra advisor commission)

TC Credits must be used on the same sailing - they cannot be banked for future cruises.

CONVERSATION 17 · Article 2

ADVISOR

What's typical attrition for groups?

SIDEKICK

Typical attrition for groups is 15-20% below your block size. This means you need to fill 80-85% of your room block to avoid penalties.

CONVERSATION 18 · Article 7

ADVISOR

How do GAP Points work?

SIDEKICK

GAP Points (Group Amenity Points) are cruise line perks awarded to groups based on total cabins booked. The formula varies by cruise line, but typically:

- 10 cabins = 50 GAP points
- 20 cabins = 120 GAP points
- 40 cabins = 300 GAP points

You can redeem GAP Points for:

- Onboard credit (OBC) for travelers
- Welcome amenities (champagne, chocolates, gifts in cabins)
- Group events (happy hours, private parties)
- Wi-Fi packages
- Specialty dining
- Shore excursions

Work with your cruise line group coordinator 30-60 days before sailing to select amenities.

CONVERSATION 19 · Article 4

ADVISOR

What's a good attrition rate for a corporate group?

SIDEKICK

For corporate groups, aim for 15-18% attrition. Corporate groups typically have confirmed attendees, though last-minute changes can happen due to business needs or schedule conflicts. This range balances good pricing with reasonable risk management.

CONVERSATION 20 · Article 7

ADVISOR

What's the difference between a cabin and a berth on a cruise?

SIDEKICK

This is an important distinction! Cruise lines measure groups in staterooms/cabins, not passengers (berths).

- Cabin/Stateroom: The physical room
- Berth: An individual bed/passenger

For group minimums:

- A cabin with 2 passengers = 1 cabin toward your group minimum (not 2)
- A cabin with 4 passengers = still 1 cabin (not 4)

So 8 cabins with 32 passengers total still equals only 8 cabins for group booking purposes.

CONVERSATION 21 · Article 7

ADVISOR

What's a charter cruise booking?

SIDEKICK

A charter is when you book exclusive use of an entire ship or a large section (typically 100+ cabins). Charter bookings offer:

Features:

- Buyout of ship or significant portion
- Custom itineraries possible
- Exclusive events and branding
- Significant upfront commitment
- Highest level of customization

Best for:

- Large corporate incentive groups
- Destination weddings with 100+ guests
- Conferences or conventions
- Ultra-luxury private experiences

Charters require substantial deposits (often 25%+ of total) and involve working directly with the cruise line's event planning team.

CONVERSATION 22 · Article 9

ADVISOR

I'm quoting a 30-room Hyatt group - what commission should I expect?

SIDEKICK

For a Hyatt group, you can expect around 8-10% commission on the total room revenue. With 30 rooms, you're in the standard group commission tier for major hotel chains.

CONVERSATION 23 · Article 7

ADVISOR

When should I convert a spec hold to contracted?

SIDEKICK

Consider converting from speculative to contracted when:

- Your group size justifies better contracted rates
- The recall date is approaching
- You've reached 60-70% of your target cabin count
- The sailing is filling up and you want to lock inventory

The conversion process involves contacting your cruise line group desk, negotiating contracted terms, and submitting a deposit. Existing spec bookings will transfer to the contracted block.

CONVERSATION 24 · Article 5

ADVISOR

What's the typical deposit schedule for hotel groups?

SIDEKICK

Most hotel group contracts require:

1. Initial deposit: 20-30% at contract signing
2. Second deposit: 60 days before arrival
3. Final payment: 30 days before arrival

However, deposit schedules are negotiable based on group size and hotel policy. For events far out (6+ months), you may be able to spread payments across more intervals.

CONVERSATION 25 · Article 7

ADVISOR

When is final payment due for cruise groups?

SIDEKICK

For most cruise sailings over 6 nights, final payment is due 120 days before sailing. Shorter cruises have different timelines:

- 2-5 night cruises: 75 days before sailing
- 6+ night cruises: 120 days before sailing

This is when all travelers' final payments must be submitted to the cruise line.

CONVERSATION 26 · Article 3

ADVISOR

Can I negotiate resort fees for my 30-room wedding block?

SIDEKICK

Resort fees are typically non-negotiable at resort properties as they're built into the pricing model. However, it never hurts to ask during contract negotiations, especially for a group of 30 rooms. You might have better luck getting other concessions like complimentary breakfast or welcome amenities instead.

CONVERSATION 27 · Article 5

ADVISOR

Should I collect payments from individual travelers or have the group organizer collect?

SIDEKICK

There are two models, each with pros and cons:

Model 1: Advisor Collects from Travelers

- Pros: Full control, direct traveler relationship, can track who paid
- Cons: Time-intensive, you're responsible if travelers don't pay, need merchant account
- Best for: Small groups (10-20 travelers)

Model 2: Group Organizer Collects

- Pros: Less admin work, organizer is responsible for collection, one point of contact
- Cons: Less visibility into who paid, dependent on organizer's follow-through
- Best for: Larger groups, corporate groups, weddings

Choose based on group size and organizer reliability.

CONVERSATION 28 · Article 7

ADVISOR

What commission do cruises typically pay on groups?

SIDEKICK

Standard cruise group commission is approximately 16%. Luxury cruise lines may offer 18-20%, and some cruise lines offer tiered commission structures where larger groups earn higher commission rates (e.g., 16% for 8-15 cabins, 17% for 16-30 cabins, 18% for 31+ cabins).

CONVERSATION 29 · Article 5

ADVISOR

How far in advance should I set my internal payment deadlines vs. hotel deadlines?

SIDEKICK

It's recommended to set your internal deadlines earlier than supplier deadlines to give yourself a buffer.

For example:

- If hotel wants final payment 30 days out, tell clients it's due 40 days out
- If hotel cut-off is 45 days, set your internal cut-off at 55-60 days

This gives you time to follow up with late payers and adjust your room block if needed before the hotel's hard deadline.

CONVERSATION 30 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What's a courtesy hold?

SIDEKICK

A courtesy hold is an informal room block offered by some hotels for groups below the 10-room minimum (typically 5-8 rooms). These holds:

- Don't require a formal contract
- Usually no deposit upfront
- Are not guaranteed (hotel can release rooms)
- Useful for small weddings or family reunions

Since they're below group minimums, you won't get group contract terms, but it helps keep rooms together.

CONVERSATION 31 · Article 1

ADVISOR

If my group is split across multiple hotels, how are group minimums calculated?

SIDEKICK

Each property is evaluated separately for group minimums. For example:

- 6 rooms at Hotel A = Does not meet 10-room minimum
- 5 rooms at Hotel B = Does not meet 10-room minimum
- Total 11 rooms across both = Still book as FIT at each property

You need to meet the 10-room minimum at a single property to qualify for group rates and contracts at that property.

CONVERSATION 32 · Article 9

ADVISOR

What's standard cruise commission?

SIDEKICK

Standard cruise commission for groups is 15-16%. Luxury cruise lines typically offer 18-20%, and some lines have tiered structures where larger groups earn higher percentages.

CONVERSATION 33 · Article 6

ADVISOR

What's the group minimum for tour operators?

SIDEKICK

Most tour operators require a minimum of 10+ travelers for group pricing. Some operators may accommodate 8-10 travelers at higher per-person pricing. Ideal group size is typically 15-25 travelers, and groups of 30+ may qualify for private departures or custom terms.

CONVERSATION 34 · Article 1

ADVISOR

Do all-inclusive resorts have different group minimums?

SIDEKICK

All-inclusive resorts typically follow the same 10+ room minimum as hotels. Some all-inclusive brands may offer group coordinators or perks starting at 8 rooms, but 10+ is the standard threshold for formal group contracts.

CONVERSATION 35 · Article 7

ADVISOR

What's the minimum for river cruise groups?

SIDEKICK

River cruises often have lower minimums than ocean cruises, typically 5-6 staterooms depending on the cruise line. However, this can vary by river cruise company, so it's best to check with the specific line's group desk.

CONVERSATION 36 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What happens if my group doesn't meet attrition?

SIDEKICK

If your group doesn't meet the attrition minimum, you (or the client) pay for the shortfall. Most commonly, you pay the contracted rate for unfilled rooms.

For example:

- 40-room block with 25% attrition (must fill 30 rooms)
- Only 28 rooms fill
- You owe payment for 2 additional rooms at the contracted rate

Some contracts calculate attrition on revenue rather than rooms, and rarely, hotels may waive penalties if they re-sell your released rooms - but don't count on this.

CONVERSATION 37 · Article 3

ADVISOR

Can I reduce my room block before the cut-off date?

SIDEKICK

Sometimes. Many contracts allow a one-time reduction (often 10-20% of the original block) without penalty if done 60-90 days before arrival. This needs to be negotiated and included in your contract terms. Always check your specific contract for reduction clauses.

CONVERSATION 38 · Article 3

ADVISOR

What's a sliding scale cancellation policy?

SIDEKICK

A sliding scale cancellation policy means cancellation penalties increase as the arrival date approaches. A typical structure looks like:

- 90+ days out: Full refund minus deposit
- 60-89 days: 25% penalty
- 30-59 days: 50% penalty
- 0-29 days: 100% penalty (full payment due)

This protects both the hotel and the client - more flexibility further out, stricter closer to arrival.

CONVERSATION 39 · Article 4

ADVISOR

My hotel offered 20% attrition for a wedding - should I negotiate lower?

SIDEKICK

You could try! The article recommends 15% attrition for weddings since guest lists are usually firm. If you've already collected deposits and are confident in your headcount, negotiating down to 15% could get you a better rate. Lower attrition = better pricing but higher risk.

CONVERSATION 40 · Article 8

ADVISOR

I have 24 cruise cabins and earned 3 TC Credits - what's the best way to use them?

SIDEKICK

With 3 TC Credits, you have several options:

1. Use for free cabins: Most common - provide 3 free inside cabins for group leaders or tour conductors
2. Convert to commission: Contact your cruise line to convert credits to additional commission
3. Use for group amenities: Apply toward onboard events like private cocktail parties or specialty dining

Each TC credit typically equals one free inside cabin. You'll need to decide based on what adds most value for your group - free cabins for organizers or extra commission for yourself.

CONVERSATION 41 · Article 8

ADVISOR

Can I use 1 TC credit for a cabin and convert the other 2 to commission?

SIDEKICK

I don't have specific information about splitting TC credit redemption. I'd recommend contacting your cruise line group coordinator to ask about your redemption options and whether you can allocate different credits in different ways.

CONVERSATION 42 · Article 8

ADVISOR

How much commission do I get if I convert a TC credit?

SIDEKICK

TC Credits can be converted to additional commission, but the exact amount varies by cruise line and sailing. You'll need to contact your cruise line group coordinator to get the specific conversion rate for your booking.

CONVERSATION 43 · Article 10

ADVISOR

Should I use a DMC or tour operator for my group trip to Japan?

SIDEKICK

Here's the difference:

Tour Operator: Creates and sells packaged travel experiences including accommodations, transportation, activities, and guides. Best for pre-packaged, budget-friendly group travel with set itineraries.

DMC (Destination Management Company): Provides on-the-ground services in a specific destination like transfers, local guides, and activity coordination. Best for custom, high-touch experiences.

For Japan, if you want a pre-built package, go with a tour operator. If you need local coordination and custom experiences, use a DMC.

CONVERSATION 44 · Article 10

ADVISOR

My client wants a custom 25-person Japan trip with specific hotels and experiences - DMC or TO?

SIDEKICK

For a custom itinerary with specific requirements, a DMC would be your best choice. DMCs specialize in highly customizable experiences and work with your specific dates and preferences. Tour operators typically offer pre-built packages with less flexibility.

CONVERSATION 45 · Article 10

ADVISOR

What commission do DMCs pay?

SIDEKICK

DMCs typically pay 10-15% commission on services booked. The exact rate varies by destination, services provided, and volume of business. Commission is usually paid 30-60 days after travel is complete.

CONVERSATION 46 · Article 3

ADVISOR

Can I negotiate the 1:40 comp room ratio?

SIDEKICK

The standard complimentary room ratio is 1:40 (one comp room per 40 paid rooms). This is the industry standard ratio that most hotels follow for group bookings.

CONVERSATION 47 · Article 3

ADVISOR

My wedding group has 35 rooms - can I get better than 1:40 comp ratio?

SIDEKICK

With 35 rooms, you're just under the 40-room threshold for a complimentary room at the standard 1:40 ratio. Unfortunately, you wouldn't qualify for any comp rooms at this size. You'd need 40 paid rooms to get 1 comp room.

CONVERSATION 48 · Article 10

ADVISOR

How far in advance should I book a group trip to Italy?

SIDEKICK

For group travel, you'll want to book well in advance to secure inventory and get the best rates. I'd recommend reaching out 6-12 months before travel, especially for popular destinations like Italy. Tour operators and DMCs need lead time to plan custom itineraries and lock in hotels.

CONVERSATION 49 · Articles 1, 3, 10

ADVISOR

What's a good price per person for a 20-person group trip to Japan?

SIDEKICK

I don't have specific pricing information for Japan group trips in the knowledge base. Pricing varies significantly based on:

- Length of trip
- Accommodation level (budget vs luxury)
- Whether using tour operator vs DMC
- Season (cherry blossom season vs off-peak)
- Specific cities and experiences included

I'd recommend reaching out to the Tour Ops team who can provide destination-specific guidance for Japan group pricing and connect you with preferred partners.

CONVERSATION 50 · Articles 1, 3

ADVISOR

What's the best attrition rate for my wedding block of 40 rooms?

SIDEKICK

The best attrition rate depends on several factors specific to your situation:

- How confident are you about guest attendance?
- Have you already collected deposits from guests?
- How far out is the wedding?
- What's your risk tolerance?

Industry standard for weddings is 20-25% attrition. If you're very confident and have deposits, you might negotiate lower for better rates. If there's uncertainty, higher attrition (25-30%) provides more protection. I'd recommend discussing your specific situation with the Booking Platform team to determine the right balance for your group.